Comfort is Required

Ethics of Pain Management for MOLST Option B

Core Ethical Concepts

Ethical Principle	Application to Option B Pain Management
Autonomy	The patient (or decision-maker) chose a comfort-focused approach. Providing effective analgesia honors that choice.
Beneficence	The primary duty is to relieve suffering. Uncontrolled pain fails this obligation.
Non-maleficence	Withholding needed pain relief causes harm. So does giving interventions the patient has declined.
Double Effect	Analgesics may secondarily hasten death. This is ethically and legally acceptable when the intent is relief of suffering and dosing is proportionate.
Dignity	Comfort supports dignity and quality of remaining life. Pain undermines both.





Key Legal Anchor

Maryland Health-General § 5-608 states that DNR/MOLST orders may not be used to withhold interventions necessary for comfort care or pain relief.

Criminal Law § 3-103 protects providers who give medication to relieve pain even if it may hasten death, as long as the intent is not to cause death.

© 2026 Mark Johnson. This work is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License.